

Duke Life Experiences Statement

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Raised in Palo Alto, I benefited from a highly motivated academic culture shaped by dedicated and inspiring teachers. At the same time, I became aware that many of my peers shared similar backgrounds and perspectives, which led me to seek a more diverse intellectual environment. Despite having the option to remain in California, I made a deliberate decision to pursue my undergraduate education in Canada. Part of that decision was driven by Canada's cultural and socioeconomic diversity, which I saw as an opportunity to learn in a setting shaped by a wider range of perspectives and lived experiences than those I had previously encountered.

I was raised to believe that hard work reliably leads to success. While this belief shaped my confidence, it did not account for how unevenly resources and opportunities are distributed. Learning alongside classmates whose academic paths were constrained by factors beyond effort alone challenged this assumption and reshaped how I understand achievement. This shift has deeply influenced how I think about teaching. I began to recognize the unequal conditions under which students learn, and how teaching can either reinforce or reduce barriers.

Teaching has been a significant part of my undergraduate experience, from working as a teaching assistant, working as the director of statistics for the departmental student association, running review seminars for various courses, to preparing and sharing course notes with classmates. These roles placed me in close conversation with students from varied backgrounds, making the inequities I had observed in the classroom both visible and tangible. Listening to students describe balancing coursework with external responsibilities or navigating unfamiliar academic systems challenged my assumptions about preparedness and reinforced the need for intentional, accessible teaching.

In response, I took deliberate steps to make learning materials more accessible. For my tutorial sessions I oversee, I made sure to post annotated notes and concise summaries for those that aren't able to attend. I also made sure to adjust office hour times throughout the semester to accommodate different schedules, and offer additional hours near exam season. For review seminars, I made sure to offer both an in-person seminar, and a recorded zoom session for students unable to attend live. I also worked to reduce barriers that are often left implicit, such as clarifying expectations, connecting students directly to professors, and creating spaces where students felt comfortable asking foundational questions. These practices reinforced my belief that accessibility is not an add-on to teaching, but central to effective instruction.

As I commence my journey through graduate studies and beyond, I see teaching not as a parallel responsibility to research, but as an integral part of it. I hope to continue developing accessible instructional practices through transparent course design, flexible modes of engagement, and mentorship that acknowledges diverse paths into academia. As statistics increasingly shapes inquiry across disciplines, I see accessible statistical education as essential, not only for statisticians, but for students in fields where quantitative tools inform research, policy, and decision-making. I am especially motivated to teach statistics in ways that resonate with students for whom mathematics is not their primary discipline, emphasizing intuition, context, and practical relevance alongside formal rigor.

Pursuing a master's degree in statistics represents a natural continuation of my academic and teaching experiences. Working closely with students has reinforced the importance of clear assumptions, transparent methods, and careful interpretation principles that are central to both effective teaching and responsible statistical practice. I aim to carry this perspective into graduate study, where I can deepen my technical training while remaining attentive to how statistical knowledge is communicated and applied. My commitment to teaching has also shaped why I am drawn to statistics. Statistical reasoning sits at the intersection of theory and interpretation, and I have seen firsthand how gaps in explanation or context can become barriers to understanding. Through a master's in statistics, I hope to strengthen my technical foundation while continuing to refine approaches that make complex quantitative ideas accessible without sacrificing precision. At Duke, I hope to grow as both a statistician and an educator, contributing to a community that values precision in analysis and care in communication.